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Central Ideas and Details

10 questions · ~15 min

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INFORMATION AND IDEAS

Xin Wang and colleagues have discovered the earliest known example of a flower bud in a 164-million-year-old plant fossil in China. The researchers have named the new species *Florigerminis jurassica*. They believe that the discovery pushes the emergence of flowering plants, or angiosperms, back to the Jurassic period, which occurred between 145 million and 201 million years ago.

According to the text, how old was the fossil that Wang and colleagues discovered?

- A. 150 million years old
- B. 145 million years old
- C. 164 million years old
- D. 201 million years old

NASA's *Cassini* probe has detected an unusual wobble in the rotation of Mimas, Saturn's smallest moon. Using a computer model to study Mimas's gravitational interactions with Saturn and tidal forces, geophysicist Alyssa Rhoden and colleagues have proposed that this wobble could be due to a liquid ocean moving beneath the moon's icy surface. The researchers believe other moons should be examined to see if they too might have oceans hidden beneath their surfaces.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Rhoden and colleagues were the first to confirm that several of Saturn's moons contain hidden oceans.
- B. Research has failed to identify signs that there is an ocean hidden beneath the surface of Mimas.
- C. Rhoden and colleagues created a new computer model that identifies moons with hidden oceans without needing to analyze the moons' rotation.
- D. Research has revealed that an oddity in the rotation of Mimas could be explained by an ocean hidden beneath its surface.

Scrapbooks of saved fabric pieces were commonly kept by women in the nineteenth-century United States, but few are as meticulously detailed as Hannah Ditzler Alspaugh's work. Alongside each piece of fabric, Alspaugh recorded intimate memories, such as dressmaking with her sister. Additionally, she listed the prices and how she used the fabric. Historians note that by representing fifty years of changing textures, patterns, and dress styles, the scrapbook is a record of nineteenth-century textiles and dressmaking as well as Alspaugh's life.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Alspaugh inspired other women to save pieces of fabric in scrapbooks and provide historical records of nineteenth-century fashions in the United States.
- B. Historians rely on fabric scrapbooks to understand how fashions changed throughout the nineteenth-century United States.
- C. Fabric scrapbooks were a popular hobby for many women in the nineteenth-century United States.
- D. Alspaugh's scrapbook provides a detailed account of her life and historical record of fashion trends in the nineteenth-century United States.

It has long been thought that the original author of the US Pledge of Allegiance was Francis Bellamy, who said that he wrote the pledge one evening in August of 1892. But a historian recently discovered a newspaper article that was published several months before August 1892. The article describes students reciting the same pledge that Bellamy claims he first wrote in August. This means that Bellamy may not have created the pledge after all.

Based on the text, what piece of knowledge about the Pledge of Allegiance has recently become uncertain?

- A. How many changes were made to the pledge in the 1900s
- B. The identity of the person who first wrote the pledge
- C. The name of the newspaper that first published the pledge
- D. Which part of the pledge students liked best in 1892

The following text is from Edith Nesbit's 1902 novel *Five Children and It*. Five young siblings have just moved with their parents from London to a house in the countryside that they call the White House.

It was not really a pretty house at all; it was quite ordinary, and mother thought it was rather inconvenient, and was quite annoyed at there being no shelves, to speak of, and hardly a cupboard in the place. Father used to say that the ironwork on the roof and coping was like an architect's nightmare. But the house was deep in the country, with no other house in sight, and the children had been in London for two years, without so much as once going to the seaside even for a day by an excursion train, and so the White House seemed to them a sort of Fairy Palace set down in an Earthly Paradise.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Although their parents believe the house has several drawbacks, the children are enchanted by it.
- B. The children don't like the house nearly as much as their parents do.
- C. Each member of the family admires a different characteristic of the house.
- D. The house is beautiful and well built, but the children miss their old home in London.

In the 1960s, Chavela Vargas became an unlikely star in ranchera, a style of traditional Mexican music. Most ranchera singers had clear, polished voices and performed with a full band. But Vargas accompanied her raspy voice with just her guitar. Dressed in men's trousers and a poncho, she would perform classic songs that had been written from a male point of view and were usually sung by men. She also altered those songs by performing them much more slowly than other ranchera singers did. The slower tempo allowed her to express the emotional quality of the lyrics more fully.

According to the text, what is one way that Vargas differed from other ranchera singers?

- A. She possessed a voice that was clear and polished.
- B. She avoided singing songs written from a male point of view.
- C. She disliked performing classic songs.
- D. She altered classic songs by slowing them down.

Shimmering is a collective defense behavior that researchers have observed in giant honeybee colonies. When shimmering, different groups of bees flip their bodies up and down in what looks like waves. This defense is initiated when hornets hover near a colony, serving to deter the hornets from approaching the bees. Researchers hypothesize that this behavior is a specialized defense response to hornets, as it is not observed when other, larger predators approach the colony.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Researchers are unsure how giant honeybees defend against predators larger than hornets.
- B. Researchers think that shimmering in giant honeybees is a specific defense against hornets.
- C. Hornets are known to be the main predator of giant honeybees.
- D. Several different species of insects use shimmering to defend against hornets.

Bicycles were first mass-produced in the late nineteenth century throughout Europe and North America, allowing individuals remarkable freedom to travel longer distances quickly and comfortably. This freedom, coupled with the affordability of the vehicle, made the bicycle immensely popular. Individuals were able to live farther from their workplaces, easily visit neighboring towns, and participate in new leisure and sport activities. Bicycling quickly became a popular social endeavor, with enthusiasts forming local cycling clubs to enjoy these newfound activities with others.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. The widespread adoption of the bicycle in the late nineteenth century provided new opportunities for people.
- B. The affordability of the bicycle in the late nineteenth century made it the preferred way to travel.
- C. The popularity of the bicycle in the late nineteenth century gave rise to the first cycling clubs.
- D. The mass production of the bicycle in the late nineteenth century made it safer for people to use.

Archaeologist Veronica Waweru visited the Lewa Wildlife Conservancy in Kenya. While exploring there, Waweru noticed many rows of shallow pits carved into stone. Waweru believed the pits could have been used as game boards to play ancient versions of mancala, a two-person strategy game that is still popular today. Some of the more recent pits were carved on top of older pits. This led Waweru to think that the game was played at the site for a long time.

According to the text, why does Waweru think that mancala was played at the site for a long time?

- A. Some of the newer pits were carved on top of the older pits.
- B. She noticed many rows of shallow pits carved into stone.
- C. She discovered the pits at the Lewa Wildlife Conservancy.
- D. Some of the pits were shallow and others were quite deep.

The following text is from Jane Austen's 1811 novel *Sense and Sensibility*. Elinor lives with her younger sisters and her mother, Mrs. Dashwood.

Elinor, this eldest daughter, whose advice was so effectual, possessed a strength of understanding, and coolness of judgment, which qualified her, though only nineteen, to be the counsellor of her mother, and enabled her frequently to counteract, to the advantage of them all, that eagerness of mind in Mrs. Dashwood which must generally have led to imprudence. She had an excellent heart;—her disposition was affectionate, and her feelings were strong; but she knew how to govern them: it was a knowledge which her mother had yet to learn; and which one of her sisters had resolved never to be taught.

According to the text, what is true about Elinor?

- A. Elinor often argues with her mother but fails to change her mind.
- B. Elinor can be overly sensitive with regard to family matters.
- C. Elinor thinks her mother is a bad role model.
- D. Elinor is remarkably mature for her age.